

FAMOUS VOWS

By Arsly Mwamwaya

Take a break,
quench your thirst.
Let the noise of the day
melt like sugar in tea.
The night does not rush you,
it waits,
ready to listen.

Somewhere,
love once whispered famous vows.
Not loud, not proud,
just soft enough
for the stars to lean closer.

They said:
“Ndiwe wane mpaka fumu yize”
I will stay when the world grows quiet.
I will hold you when your heart forgets its rhythm.
I will believe in you,
even when you don't.

Those words never died;
they traveled,
through generations,
through gentle hands,

through the warmth
in a stranger's smile.

But hell,
that was then.

Not now.

You never imagined
the life I'm living,
but I'm living it
all the same.

Desires go unnoticed;
is this how we get close
to each other's minds?
From dear and darling
Now am called nyajere

"I will change, darling,"
you say.

My shelter
in a world of beasts,
your calmness
is what I need
to gather myself.

Change, huh?

Yes, you changed.

You live your life
without consequence.

While I grow each day,
you make me younger,
small again,
as my words go unheard.

You stitched my mouth
with your money,
so dear.

Go on then,
stitch a little more.
You've missed a spot
right here.

Famous vows,
just a rumor now,
a story whispered
but never practiced,
never meant
to last forever.